WEEK 1: Banking & Finance – Investor Preferences Survey

Executive Report and Project Documentation

Project: Investor Preferences Survey
Dataset: Finance_data.csv
Sample Size: 40 respondents
Business Context: Financial advisory startup

1. Problem Statement & Methodology

The project aimed to analyze the demographic characteristics, savings objectives, and investment preferences of 40 survey respondents to help a financial advisory startup identify preferred investment avenues and develop targeted customer engagement strategies.

- **Data Preparation & Engineering:** Raw survey data was cleaned, standardized, and structured entirely within **Microsoft Excel**. Field formats were validated, missing/unclear data audited, and variables organized into clean tabular structures.
- **Analytical Approach & Tooling:** Excel was leveraged for core data modeling, summary statistics, pivot cross-tabulations, dynamic lookup tables (XLOOKUP), conditional logic, and synchronized slicers. Additionally, AI tools including **ChatGPT, Gemini, and Claude** were utilized for domain exploration and data understanding, providing guidance on financial concepts and variable logic while navigating a banking dataset for the first time.

2. Key Findings

- **Demographics:** The average age of respondents was 28 years, indicating a young, tech-savvy target audience for the advisory start-up.
- **Savings Objectives:** Retirement planning was the primary objective for 24 respondents (60%), followed by healthcare security at 13 respondents (32.5%), and education at 3 respondents (7.5%).
- **Information Sources:** Financial consultants led as the primary source of financial advice at 40%, closely followed by internet sources at 35% (a combined 75% market share), television at 15%, and print media at 10%.
- **Investment Preference Rankings & Behavioral Disconnect:**
    - Average rank scores across avenues showed Public Provident Fund (PPF) at **2**, Mutual Funds and Equity Market at **3** each, Fixed Deposits at **4**, Government Bonds at **5**, and Debentures and Gold at **6** each.
    - **Key Behavioral Insight:** Cross-analysis revealed a notable disconnect between numerical rank scores and actual avenue selections. Many products/avenues were assigned a rank of 7 yet were *not* selected as a chosen avenue, while other avenues received lower rank scores but were explicitly selected by respondents. This demonstrates that **final avenue choices were made independently of the numerical ranking column**.

- **Interactive Dashboard:** An executive dashboard was created in Excel, featuring dynamic KPI cards displaying selected avenues alongside their average ranks, cross-tabulated charts, and synchronized chart slicers.

3. Limitations & Data Ambiguities

- **Ranking Scale Ambiguity:** There was inherent uncertainty regarding whether **1** represented the highest/best rank or **7** represented the highest rank in the raw survey schema.
- **Disconnect Between Ranking & Choice:** Because respondents selected avenues that did not align predictably with their numeric ranks (e.g., selecting avenues with lower rank values or ignoring those ranked at 7), the numerical rankings cannot be treated as a strict predictor of actual investment behavior.
- **Sample Constraints & Scope:** The dataset is limited to 40 respondents, restricting broad statistical generalization. Analysis remains descriptive rather than proving direct causal relationships.

4. Strategic Recommendations

- **Investigate Customer Decision Drivers:** Prior to launching targeted product campaigns, conduct qualitative follow-ups to clarify what drove respondents' final avenue selections over their numerical rank scores.
- **Develop Retirement-Centric Offerings:** Capitalize on the 60% demand for retirement planning by crafting tailored, long-term wealth accumulation packages and educational content.
- **Adopt a Hybrid Marketing Model:** Allocate outreach budgets across both digital platforms (35% reach) and direct consultant partnerships (40% reach) to maximize customer acquisition.
- **Promote High-Selection Products:** Focus primary promotional campaigns on avenues that showed actual adoption (like Equity and Mutual Funds) rather than relying solely on raw rank averages.
- **Maintain Dashboard Integrity:** Periodically audit workbook formulas and slicer connections as new survey responses are added to the Excel sheet.